

Papa Was a Rollin' Stone -- The Temptations (Bass)

Bass: Harley Benton P/J, 5-string, passive. Full board.

1972. Norman Whitfield production, Funk Brothers session band. ~120 BPM (estimate).

The bass line *is* the song. One ostinato, repeated for 7 minutes on the single and close to 12 on the album version.

The bass part is generally credited to Bob Babbitt.

The target is the classic Detroit P-bass sound: flatwounds, a muted, round attack, deep fundamental, almost no top end.

The P/J has roundwounds, so the flatwound thump has to come from the pickup choice, the tone knob, and the treble cuts below.

Instrument setup:

- P pickup volume: full. J pickup volume: 0. P alone is the Motown sound.
- Tone knob: about 40% (rolled back). This does most of the flatwound imitation.
- Play with the side of your palm resting lightly on the strings at the bridge. That stands in for the foam mute on a vintage P-bass.
- Pluck over the neck end of the P pickup. Round, not snappy.

CTL off = the main groove. CTL on = the same groove with a small level lift for when the strings and horns pile in.

GP-5 settings

Module order: NR -> PRE -> DST -> AMP -> CAB -> EQ -> MOD -> DLY -> RVB.

NR -- Gate (always on)

- THRE: 15

Low threshold. Passive P pickup hum is mild.

The muted notes are short already. A higher threshold would chop the tail of the sustained ostinato notes.

PRE -- Micro Boost (CTL)

- Gain: 32
- CTL off: bypassed. CTL on: engaged.

A clean level lift, roughly +3dB, no tone change.

The arrangement grows a lot: strings, horns, wah guitar, orchestral hits. The bass line doesn't change, so it needs a little more level to hold its ground as the mix gets denser.

Gain 32 is a nudge, not a volume jump.

DST -- off

Clean. Any audible grit is wrong for this record.

AMP -- Classic Bass (Ampeg SVT) (always on)

- Gain: 30, Bass: 62, Middle: 46, MidFreq: 450Hz, Treble: 34, VOL: 66

Gain 30 keeps it clean with a little tube warmth.

Bass 62 for that deep, full fundamental.

Middle 46 at 450Hz takes a small scoop out of the honk zone. That keeps the thump round instead of boxy.

Treble 34 is the second half of the flatwound imitation, after the tone knob.

CAB -- User IR 1 (Apg115) (always on)

- VOL: 62

Ampeg B-15, 1x15. This is the Detroit studio bass amp of the era, and the IR is loaded and encoded.

Its 100Hz peak is exactly the girth this line wants.

Classic Bass into Apg115 is the same brand family, per ir.md's own pairing.

EQ -- Bass EQ 2 (always on)

- 50Hz: +1, 120Hz: +3, 400Hz: -2, 800Hz: +2, 4.5kHz: -7, VOL: 52

-7 at 4.5kHz is the biggest move. It cuts roundwound zing and finger noise. Flatwounds don't have that top end.

+3 at 120Hz reinforces the B-15 thump.

Only +1 at 50Hz. The 5-string's low B and the line's low notes can boom on a small room system, so the low end stays controlled.

+2 at 800Hz keeps enough note definition that the ostinato reads clearly on small speakers.

-2 at 400Hz matches the amp's mid scoop: round, not boxy.

Same in both CTL states.

MOD -- off

No modulation.

DLY -- off

Not used.

RVB -- off

Motown bass is dry and up front. Any reverb blurs the pocket.

CTL summary

- **CTL Off -- Main groove.** Round, deep, muted, dry. This is 90% of the song.
- **CTL On -- Dense sections.** Same tone plus Micro Boost, about +3dB.
- Engage CTL when the strings and horns stack up in the extended vamps and the orchestral swells.
- Drop back to CTL Off for the sparse intro (bass, hi-hat, handclaps) and under the vocal verses.
- Honestly optional. The line never changes. If the mix is balanced, you can leave CTL off all night.

Full pedalboard (signal chain order)

1. Flamma FS-08 Octave -- Bypassed

- -2OCT: 0, -OCT: 0, +OCT: 0, +2OCT: 0, Dry: 100

- Footswitch off.

The line is already low and fat. An octave voice would turn a clean Motown thump into synth bass.

2. Donner Ultimate Comp -- Engaged

- COMP: 40
- TONE: 40
- LEVEL: 55
- Mode: NORMAL

Keeps every repetition of the ostinato at the same level. That evenness over 7+ minutes is half the feel.

TONE 40 keeps the comp from putting back the top end we're cutting everywhere else.

NORMAL mode. TREBLE mode is the opposite of what a flatwound imitation needs.

3. Donner Stylish Fuzz -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off.

No fuzz on this record.

4. Joyo Tidal Wave -- Engaged (as a clean preamp; Drive effectively out)

- Drive: 15
- Blend: 10
- Presence: 25
- Level: 55
- Treble: 38
- Middle: 52
- Bass: 60
- Mid-Frequency: 500Hz
- Bass-Shift: 80Hz
- Cab-Sim (DI out): Off. Ground Lift: Off. Only matters if you're using the DI out.

It's there for EQ and a touch of preamp weight, not drive.

Blend 10 with Drive 15 means the driven path is barely in the mix. That's a hint of warmth, like a pushed B-15, with no audible grit. Don't bring Drive in at any point in this song.

Bass-Shift 80Hz tightens the low end on the 5-string, so it thumps instead of booming.

Mid-Frequency 500Hz, Middle 52: essentially flat body. The GP-5's EQ handles the mid shaping.

Treble 38 and Presence 25 start the treble roll-off early in the chain.

5. Joyo Narcissus -- Bypassed

- Footswitch off.

No chorus. Matches the MOD-off call on the GP-5.

6. Valeton GP-5 -- see settings above.

The `.prst` only carries the GP-5's 9 modules. The pedalboard settings above are not stored in the file. Set them by hand.